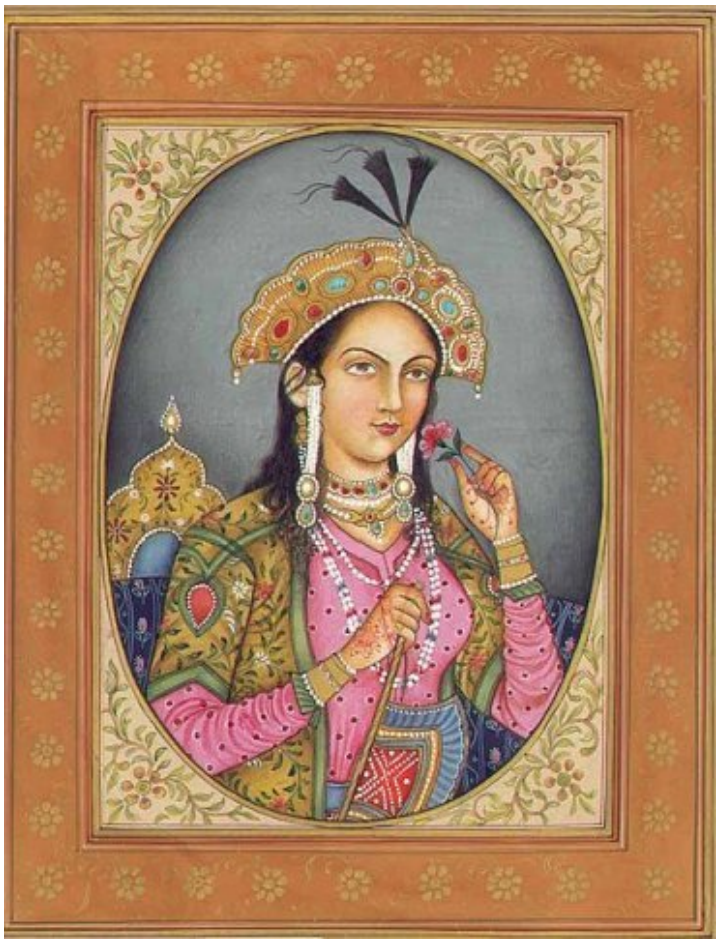
The Shah, a title last used by the Shahs of Iran, had six wives, even though up to four are normally permitted by Islamic law, but accounts agree that his relationship with his third wife, Mumtaz Mahal, was unusually close. Mumtaz, whose name means "chosen one of the palace" in Persian, was by all accounts a beautiful noble woman, and the two of them were so inseparable that she accompanied him on his journeys. In kind, she also wielded considerable power behind the throne after elbowing out a rival wife, Arjumand Banu Begum, and in the end, she was the custodian of the royal seal, which meant that laws could not be made official without her review. Unfortunately, in 1630, shortly after her husband's ascendancy to the throne, she died at age 40 due to complications of childbirth. In total, she gave birth to seven children, including the sixth emperor, Aurangzeb[1].



A posthumous Mughal painting that depicts Mumtaz Mahal.

Accounts of the time note that the Shah and his family were crushed by the news. The oldest daughter, Princess Jahanara is said to have given away her